

01

THE THREE QUESTIONS EVERY PROOF MUST SURVIVE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Core argument: Every proof must be tested for validity, soundness and adequacy: whether the conclusion follows, the premises are true and the being reached is genuinely God.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Almost every UPSC critique question ("critically examine", "along with its criticism") is answered by locating the objection on one of these three tiers instead of shouting a general "the proof fails".

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Preference therefore depends on the criterion — evidential contact favours a posteriori, modal strength favours a priori, and religious adequacy is achieved by neither alone.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□□ Never write "Kant proves God through morality." Kant explicitly denies theoretical proof, he postulates.

ANSWER LINE: MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

02

THE ONTOLOGICAL ARGUMENT AS A REDUCTIO

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Recommended opening definition: The ontological argument is an a priori attempt to derive God's necessary existence from the concept of the greatest conceivable being.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

That description would be trivially satisfied by whatever happens to be the best existing thing, with no guarantee that it is God.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Anselm's principle therefore does not apply to it.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ Anselm compresses the monotheistic concept of God into the formula "a being than which nothing greater can be conceived." "Greater" here means more perfect, not spatially larger.

ANSWER LINE: MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

03

TWO KINDS OF CAUSAL SERIES (THE WHOLE ARGUMENT TURNS ON THIS)

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Two kinds of causal series (the whole argument turns on this): □□ This diagram is the single highest-value item in the cosmological answer.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Therefore a first efficient cause must be admitted.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Unlike the ontological argument, which focuses on the idea of God and unfolds its inner implications, Aquinas' proofs start from some general feature of the world around us and argue that there could not be a world with this particular characteristic unless there also existed the ultimate reality we call God.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Recommended opening definition: Aquinas targets an essentially ordered present dependence, not merely a temporal sequence extending indefinitely into the past.

ANSWER LINE: MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

04

THREE TELEOLOGIES THAT MUST NOT BE CONFUSED

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□□ Reproducing this three-way distinction is what separates a 60% answer from a 75% answer in 2025 Q6(a).

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Most candidates write Paley, get demolished by Darwin, and stop.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

1. □ The inference is not weakened if I have never seen a watch made (as we have never seen a world other than this one) and therefore do not know from direct observation that watches are products of intelligence.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ The Fifth Way is not an analogy with human manufacture.

ANSWER LINE: MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

05

KANT'S TWO-STOREY STRUCTURE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Kant's two-storey structure: □□ The whole examinable point is in the architecture, not the content.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Kant is the destroyer of the theistic proofs and the author of a moral argument, and he sees no contradiction because the two operate on different storeys.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The Indian argument is therefore epistemically bolder and correspondingly more exposed — it must show that an unconscious principle could not do the job."

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□□ The whole examinable point is in the architecture, not the content.

ANSWER LINE: MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

06

NYĀYA'S COSMIC DIVISION OF LABOUR

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Nyāya's cosmic division of labour: It is the trap the examiner is checking for, and it is the difference between Nyāya and both Advaita and Rāmānuja.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

□ God is the creator of the world in the sense of being the first efficient cause of the world and not its material cause — "a sort of demiurgus or a builder of the ordered universe". □ He is also the preserver, in so far as the world is kept in existence by the will of God, and the destroyer, who lets loose the forces of destruction when the exigencies of the moral world require it.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

God is thus the moral governor of the world, the impartial dispenser of the fruits of our actions (karmaphaladāta), and the supreme arbiter of our joys and sorrows.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Recommended opening definition: Nyāya (school of logic and realism) infers an omniscient efficient cause that orders eternal atoms and dispenses karmic fruits, not a material creator from nothing.

ANSWER LINE: MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

07

TWO COMPLETELY DIFFERENT SENSES OF "GOD" IN THE INDIAN DEBATE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Two completely different senses of "God" in the Indian debate: □□ This is the single most important interpretive move in the entire subtopic.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

High-value transition: Creator-denial must not be equated with denial of every religious ideal, because Jainism rejects a creator while affirming achieved godhead.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ This is the single most important interpretive move in the entire subtopic.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

High-value transition: Creator-denial must not be equated with denial of every religious ideal, because Jainism rejects a creator while affirming achieved godhead.

ANSWER LINE: MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

08

PART I — JAINISM

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Recommended opening definition: Jainism rejects a creator God but affirms liberated, omniscient souls as achieved godhead attained through self-effort.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Recommended opening definition: Jainism rejects a creator God but affirms liberated, omniscient souls as achieved godhead attained through self-effort.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ The Jaina "proofs" are therefore proofs of the possibility and actuality of divine perfection in the soul, arranged as follows

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ Jainism is "a religion without God" in the sense of a creator. □ There is no necessity of bringing in God to explain creation, for the world was never created: production, destruction and permanence characterise all substances; things have creation and dissolution because of their modes (paryāya), while the substances themselves are eternal.

ANSWER LINE: MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

09

PART II — BUDDHISM

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Part II — Buddhism: 1. □ If God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation becomes difficult to explain, because willing or producing seems to involve change.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Recommended opening definition: Buddhism rejects a permanent creator and explains suffering through conditioned arising rather than divine production.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

A permanent, partless, immutable cause cannot produce successive effects, since a cause that is unchanging and fully present must produce its effect all at once and always; therefore an eternal God cannot be the cause of a temporally ordered world.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Recommended opening definition: Buddhism rejects a permanent creator and explains suffering through conditioned arising rather than divine production.

ANSWER LINE: MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

10

PART III — MĪMĀṂSĀ

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Part III — Mīmāṃsā: □ The Veda is authoritative because it is apauruṣeya — eternal, authorless and self-valid.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Recommended opening definition: Mīmāṃsā (school of inquiry into ritual duty) treats the Veda (sacred revealed knowledge) as authorless and karma (morally consequential action) as self-fructifying, thereby displacing the need for God.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Dharmakīrti-type argument: a permanent cause cannot produce successive effects.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

It is not authored by any human, nor is a divine author needed. □ Authorlessness protects it from personal defects: a personal author may deceive, or may lack complete knowledge; if the Veda had an author, its authority would depend on first proving that author's competence and sincerity.

ANSWER LINE: MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

11

□□ MASTER CONCEPT MAP — THE WHOLE SYLLABUS ITEM ON ONE PAGE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□□ MASTER CONCEPT MAP — the whole syllabus item on one page: Final verdict: No proof is demonstrative unless it survives validity, soundness and adequacy, and most arguments underdetermine the rich God of religion.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Final verdict: No proof is demonstrative unless it survives validity, soundness and adequacy, and most arguments underdetermine the rich God of religion.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□□ Choose one as the thesis of any answer, and defend it; do not hedge across all four.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□□ Choose one as the thesis of any answer, and defend it; do not hedge across all four.

ANSWER LINE: MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS